

Brookline Town Meeting Vote Summaries

May 2026 Annual Town Meeting

Held over three nights: May 26-28, 2026

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This document provides plain-language summaries of all 38 recorded votes from the May 2026 Annual Town Meeting and the concurrent Special Town Meeting. The votes covered 22 article groupings over three nights. The session combined routine annual finance work, the FY27 budget and capital bond votes, CPA appropriations, public-official stipends, Chestnut Hill Commercial zoning and agreements, immigration-enforcement by-laws and resolutions, Town Clerk office hours, zoning updates, and statewide-policy resolutions.

Source context: Brookline Current Town Meeting Files, the 2026 Annual Town Meeting combined reports with supplements, the 2026 Special Town Meeting combined reports with supplements, and the May 2026 roll-call vote workbook.

Session at a glance:

- Night 1 had 12 recorded votes, mostly routine opening and finance articles, the override stabilization fund, and Article 8 capital bond items.
- Night 2 had 9 recorded votes, including the FY27 budget main motion, CPA appropriations, public-official stipends, Advisory Committee participation, and public-records posting.
- Night 3 had 17 recorded votes, including the Chestnut Hill Commercial Special Town Meeting package, immigration-enforcement articles, Town Clerk hours, zoning changes, September 11 commemoration, and the final consent agenda.
- Every final main motion passed. The failed votes were procedural or amendment votes: divide the question on Article 9, refer Article 23, amend STM Article 1, and refer Article 17.
- The closest vote was Article 23 Motion to Refer, which failed 119-121 with 6 abstentions.

A quick guide to vote types:

- Main Motion: the vote on the article itself, often after amendments or substitutes have been resolved.
- Motion to Terminate Debate: a procedural vote to end debate and proceed to a vote; it requires a two-thirds threshold.
- Motion to Refer: a vote to send the subject away for further study instead of deciding it immediately.
- Motion to Amend or Substitute Motion: votes that change the motion before the final decision.
- Bond Vote: a separate recorded vote required for borrowing authority in the capital budget.
- Consent Agenda: a single vote used to approve multiple items together.

Article 1 - Appointment of Measurers of Wood and Bark

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action.

What this was about: This is the traditional opening article for the Annual Town Meeting. It appoints Measurers of Wood and Bark, a vestigial local office that survives mostly as a ceremonial reminder of older municipal law.

The article does not set major policy or spending priorities, but it is a regular part of organizing the meeting and making the warrant legally complete.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the appointment almost unanimously, 240-2-4. The vote signaled routine acceptance of the ceremonial opening item.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 1 Main Motion	APPROVED	240	2	4

Article 2 - Collective Bargaining Agreements

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action on the reported agreements.

What this was about: Article 2 asked Town Meeting to approve funding for collective bargaining agreements reached with municipal bargaining units. These votes are necessary because negotiated compensation and benefit changes still require

appropriation authority.

In practical terms, the vote implemented the financial pieces of labor agreements already negotiated by the Town, rather than reopening the contracts themselves.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the article 239-0-4. There was no recorded opposition, so the labor-agreement funding moved forward cleanly.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 2 Main Motion	APPROVED	239	0	4

Article 3 - Compensating Balance Agreements

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action.

What this was about: This recurring financial article authorizes the Town to use compensating balance agreements with banks. These arrangements can allow the Town to receive banking services by maintaining agreed balances rather than paying all service costs directly.

The article is administrative, but it matters because it gives the Treasurer and finance staff flexibility in managing municipal banking services.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the authorization 236-1-4, continuing the Town's annual authority to use this banking tool.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 3 Main Motion	APPROVED	236	1	4

Article 5 - FY26 Budget Amendment

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action.

What this was about: Article 5 made current-year budget adjustments for FY26. These mid-course amendments are used to align appropriations with updated costs, available revenues, and year-end operating needs.

The official reports treated the changes as necessary clean-up and adjustment work rather than a new policy debate.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the FY26 budget amendment 243-1-5. The near-unanimous vote allowed the Town to close out and manage the current fiscal year with the revised appropriations in place.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 5 Main Motion	APPROVED	243	1	5

Article 6 - Unpaid Bills from a Prior Fiscal Year

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action.

What this was about: Article 6 authorized payment of unpaid bills from a prior fiscal year. Massachusetts municipal finance rules require Town Meeting approval for certain prior-year bills, even when the underlying obligation is otherwise valid.

This is a housekeeping article, but without it the Town may lack authority to pay specific older obligations.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the article 243-0-3. There was no recorded opposition.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 6 Main Motion	APPROVED	243	0	3

Article 7 - Override Stabilization Fund

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action by a divided vote.

What this was about: Article 7 established an Override Stabilization Fund. The purpose was to create a dedicated reserve connected to the Town's override planning and future budget stability, giving the Town a place to hold money for that purpose rather than leaving it in a more general account.

The Advisory Committee recommendation was close, reflecting disagreement about the timing, design, or fiscal signal of creating this fund even among people who generally supported careful budget planning.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the stabilization fund 218-24-5. The article passed comfortably, though with more opposition than the routine finance articles earlier in the night.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 7 Main Motion	APPROVED	218	24	5

Article 8 - FY27 Budget and Capital Bond Items

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. Advisory Committee: Favorable Action on the FY27 budget.

What this was about: Article 8 was the main FY27 budget article. It included the operating budget and a set of separate bond votes for capital items, which require distinct recorded votes under state law.

The bond-item votes were narrow procedural pieces of the larger budget package. They authorized borrowing for specific capital budget lines, while the main motion approved the broader FY27 appropriations article.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved every recorded Article 8 bond item and then approved the main FY27 budget motion 237-1-3. The bond votes were effectively unanimous, with only Article 8 Bond Item 67 recording more than one No vote.

The result adopted the FY27 budget framework and the associated capital borrowing authority.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 8 Bond Item 63	APPROVED	248	0	3
Article 8 Bond Item 64	APPROVED	251	0	3
Article 8 Bond Item 65	APPROVED	251	0	3
Article 8 Bond Item 66	APPROVED	251	0	3
Article 8 Bond Item 67	APPROVED	248	2	3
Article 8 Bond Item 68	APPROVED	243	0	3
Article 8 Main Motion	APPROVED	237	1	3

Article 9 - Community Preservation Act Fund Appropriations

Board Recommendations: Community Preservation Act Committee recommendations formed the basis of the package; Town Meeting acted on the reported CPA appropriation package.

What this was about: Article 9 appropriated Community Preservation Act funds for eligible projects. CPA funds are restricted to categories such as community housing, historic preservation, open space, and recreation, so Town Meeting was deciding among project recommendations within that statutory framework.

Before the final vote, Town Meeting considered whether to divide the question so that parts of the CPA package could be voted separately.

What Town Meeting decided: The motion to divide the question failed 95-139-5, so the package stayed together. Town Meeting then approved the CPA appropriations 232-8-5.

The final outcome kept the recommended package intact and authorized the CPA spending as a single article.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 9 Motion to Divide the Question	FAILED	95	139	5
Article 9 Main Motion	APPROVED	232	8	5

Article 23 - Stipends for Public Officials

Board Recommendations: The Advisory Committee recommended referral for further study; Town Meeting instead reached final votes on the stipend resolutions.

What this was about: Article 23 addressed whether elected public officials should receive stipends. The recorded votes split the issue into Select Board stipends and School Committee stipends, after procedural votes about whether to end debate or refer the matter for additional work.

This was one of the closest and most contested topics of the meeting. The debate was not simply about compensation amounts; it also raised questions about access to public service, fiscal symbolism, and whether the policy was ready for final action.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting voted to terminate debate 193-39-7. It then rejected referral by just two votes, 119-121-6, which was the closest recorded vote of the session.

After deciding not to refer the article, Town Meeting approved both stipend resolutions: Select Board stipends by 138-89-15 and School Committee stipends by 120-114-13. The School Committee vote was especially narrow, but it still passed.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 23 Motion to Terminate Debate	APPROVED	193	39	7
Article 23 Motion to Refer	FAILED	119	121	6
Article 23 Main Motion - Select Board	APPROVED	138	89	15
Article 23 Main Motion - School Committee	APPROVED	120	114	13

Article 10 - Advisory Committee Participation in Other Town Functions

Board Recommendations: Select Board: Favorable Action. The article also reflected work by the Committee on Town Organization and Structure.

What this was about: Article 10 amended the General By-Laws to clarify when Advisory Committee members may participate in other Town functions. The issue was how to preserve the Advisory Committee's budget-review role while avoiding unnecessary restrictions on civic participation.

The practical aim was to modernize conflict and participation rules so that service on the Advisory Committee would not automatically bar useful involvement elsewhere in Town government.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the change 222-5-10. The vote showed broad support for the clarification, with a modest number of abstentions.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 10 Main Motion	APPROVED	222	5	10

Article 12 - Public Posting of Public Records Requests

Board Recommendations: The article was revised through supplemental materials before final action; Town Meeting voted on the revised version.

What this was about: Article 12 required public posting of public records requests. Supporters framed the proposal as a transparency measure that would let residents see what information was being requested from Town government.

The debate turned on how to balance transparency, administrative burden, privacy concerns, and the practical mechanics of posting requests in a consistent way.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the article 234-0-5. The final vote had no recorded No votes, indicating that the revised form answered enough concerns to pass unanimously among those voting Yes or No.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 12 Main Motion	APPROVED	234	0	5

Special Town Meeting Articles 1 and 2 - Chestnut Hill Commercial Overlay District

Board Recommendations: The Select Board and Advisory Committee reports supported the main Chestnut Hill Commercial zoning and agreement package.

What this was about: The concurrent Special Town Meeting concerned the Chestnut Hill Commercial Overlay District and related agreements for properties at 1280, 1290, 1300, and 1330 Boylston Street. Article 1 dealt with zoning map and by-law changes; Article 2 authorized related agreements, including a tax-certainty framework and restrictive covenant.

The package was one of the most consequential land-use items of the meeting. It linked zoning authority, design and development controls, transportation and fiscal questions, and negotiated public benefits into a single commercial redevelopment framework.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting first voted to terminate debate on the Special Town Meeting articles 180-42-5. It then rejected an amendment to STM Article 1 by 64-175-3.

Town Meeting approved the CHC zoning article 217-20-5 and approved the related agreements article 232-6-5. The main package therefore passed by wide margins after the amendment failed.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
STM Articles 1 and 2 Motion to Terminate Debate	APPROVED	180	42	5
STM Article 1 Motion to Amend	FAILED	64	175	3
STM Article 1 Main Motion	APPROVED	217	20	5
STM Article 2 Main Motion	APPROVED	232	6	5

Article 11 - Committee on Town Organization and Structure

Board Recommendations: The article followed recommendations from the Committee on Town Organization and Structure and received broad support in the reports.

What this was about: Article 11 changed the appointing structure and charge of the Committee on Town Organization and Structure. The committee reviews how Town government is organized and can recommend changes to the Town's governmental structure.

The article was about governance capacity: who appoints the committee, what it is charged to study, and how the Town should keep organizational reform work moving over time.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved Article 11 by 233-1-4. The near-unanimous vote adopted the governance-structure changes with minimal opposition.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 11 Main Motion	APPROVED	233	1	4

Article 17 - Civil Immigration Enforcement on Town Facilities

Board Recommendations: The Select Board supported favorable action. The Advisory Committee recommended referral and, if referral failed, no action.

What this was about: Article 17 created a new General By-Law provision prohibiting civil immigration enforcement activities on Town facilities. The article raised questions about local control of municipal property, public trust, civil rights, public safety, and the Town's relationship to federal immigration enforcement.

The procedural votes mattered because referral would have delayed final action for further study. Supporters of referral argued for more work before adopting by-law language; opponents wanted Town Meeting to decide the policy directly.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting voted to terminate debate 148-68-5, then rejected referral 81-158-3. With referral defeated, Town Meeting approved the main motion 193-35-12.

The article therefore became a Town by-law rather than being sent away for additional study.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 17 Motion to Terminate Debate	APPROVED	148	68	5
Article 17 Motion to Refer	FAILED	81	158	3
Article 17 Main Motion	APPROVED	193	35	12

Article 25 - State and Local Collaboration with Federal Immigration Enforcement

Board Recommendations: Select Board: No Action. Advisory Committee: favorable action on referral; no action on the article if referral failed.

What this was about: Article 25 was a resolution requesting discontinuance of state and local collaboration with federal immigration enforcement and related information-sharing programs. Unlike Article 17, this was a policy resolution rather than a local by-law controlling Town facilities.

The official reports show that this article involved sharp disagreement about regional information-sharing, public safety relationships, and how far Town Meeting should go in asking state and local agencies to disengage from federal immigration enforcement systems.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting voted to terminate debate 199-36-7. It then approved the main resolution 224-13-5 by a wide margin.

The final vote adopted the policy statement despite the Select Board's no-action recommendation and the Advisory Committee's preference for referral.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 25 Motion to Terminate Debate	APPROVED	199	36	7
Article 25 Main Motion	APPROVED	224	13	5

Article 13 - Town Clerk Office Hours

Board Recommendations: Recommendations were reported through supplemental materials; Town Meeting acted on a substitute motion and then the main article.

What this was about: Article 13 concerned public office hours in the Town Clerk's office. The proposal addressed the availability of in-person service and the amount of time the office should be open for residents who need clerk services.

The substitute motion indicates that Town Meeting did not simply take the original language as-is; it first approved a revised form and then voted on the article in that amended posture.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the substitute motion 152-73-7 and then approved the main motion 178-51-5. The article passed, but the vote totals show that a meaningful minority objected to at least part of the approach.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 13 Substitute Motion	APPROVED	152	73	7
Article 13 Main Motion	APPROVED	178	51	5

Article 14 - Accessory Dwelling Unit Zoning Compliance

Board Recommendations: Planning Board, Housing Advisory Board, Select Board, and Advisory Committee reports supported favorable action on the amended article.

What this was about: Article 14 amended the Zoning By-Law to comply with state requirements for Accessory Dwelling Units. State law and regulations required communities to allow ADUs under specified conditions, so Brookline needed conforming local zoning language.

The article was less about whether ADUs should exist at all and more about bringing Brookline's zoning into alignment with the state framework while preserving local implementation details where legally available.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved Article 14 by 233-1-1. The vote was effectively unanimous and adopted the ADU compliance changes.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 14 Main Motion	APPROVED	233	1	1

Article 15 - Cash-in-Lieu Threshold for Affordable Housing

Board Recommendations: Housing Advisory Board, Planning Board, Select Board, and Advisory Committee reports supported favorable action.

What this was about: Article 15 amended inclusionary zoning rules to restore a more permissive threshold allowing cash-in-lieu payments to the Affordable Housing Trust instead of on-site affordable units in certain projects.

The policy tradeoff was direct: on-site units can produce affordable homes within a development, while cash-in-lieu payments can provide flexible resources for the Affordable Housing Trust. The article favored more flexibility to accept payments in lieu of units under the specified threshold.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved Article 15 by 195-32-6. The article passed decisively, though with more opposition than the ADU compliance article.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 15 Main Motion	APPROVED	195	32	6

Article 20 - September 11 Commemoration and Memorial

Board Recommendations: Select Board and Advisory Committee reports supported favorable action on the amended article.

What this was about: Article 20 established an official annual Town-wide commemoration of September 11 and a memorial to Brookline residents who died in the attacks. The discussion included both the commemoration itself and the process for planning a suitable memorial.

The article also involved a memorial advisory function, so the vote was partly about authorizing a public remembrance and partly about creating a process for location, design, historical context, and implementation details.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting voted to terminate debate 156-47-5 and then approved the main motion 218-0-5. The final vote had no recorded opposition.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Article 20 Motion to Terminate Debate	APPROVED	156	47	5
Article 20 Main Motion	APPROVED	218	0	5

Articles 21 and 22 - Medicare for All and Proposition 2 1/2 Modernization

Board Recommendations: Advisory Committee reports supported favorable action on the final versions presented to Town Meeting.

What this was about: Article 21 was a resolution supporting Massachusetts Medicare for All legislation. Article 22 concerned modernization of Proposition 2 1/2, the state property-tax limit structure that shapes municipal revenue options.

Town Meeting handled the two statewide-policy resolutions together through a consent-agenda vote. That meant members were deciding whether to approve the package as a group rather than debating and voting on each resolution separately at that point.

What Town Meeting decided: Town Meeting approved the consent agenda for Articles 21 and 22 by 166-49-3. Both policy statements therefore moved forward through one recorded vote.

Vote	Result	Yes	No	Abstain
Articles 21 and 22 Motion to Approve as a Consent Agenda	APPROVED	166	49	3